THE PRESIDENCY

Though he did not have much of an education himself, he wanted his daughter to pursue higher studies and land a decent job. "He would often say that he would not hesitate to sell his land to send his daughter to college and university," recalls Basudev Behera, Murmu's teacher in primary school. "He in fact mortgaged his land to send her to Bhubaneswar."

To reach the school that she attended in her village till Class VII, Murmu would have to walk barefoot and cross a canal that became a full-fledged river in the monsoon months. "Such was her devotion to learning that she came to classes regularly—neither a torrential downpour nor a canal in spate could deter her," says Behera. After finishing Class VII, Murmu had two choices—go to the high school seven kilometres away or move to Bhubaneswar. She chose the latter because she was determined to study hard, secure a job and improve the fortunes of her family.

## OVERCOMING ADVERSITIES

Life at the Capital Government High School in Bhubaneswar in the early 1970s was another experience. There was only so much that she could stretch the Rs 10 her father sent her every month. "She never went to the school canteen even though we were always eager to treat her to ghugni, aloo chop and other delicacies. The free meal at the tribal hostel was all that kept her going. In her entire school and college life, she went to a cinema hall once," says Suchitra Samal, her friend in school. In class, she would sit at the back with five other tribal girls, perhaps conscious of her identity.

After graduating in the late 1970s, Murmu landed a job as a junior assistant in the irrigation department in the state headquarters in Bhubaneswar. Around this time, she got married to Shyam Charan Murmu, a bank officer in Rairangpur. The couple lived in Bhubaneswar, till the death of their daughter at a very young age brought them back to Rairangpur. Murmu began teaching at the local school, accepting an honorarium instead of a salary and earned a name for herself. She caught the attention of local BJP leader Raj Kishore Das who brought her into politics. "Since she was doing social work and helping people in her own way, I reasoned that if she joined politics, she would be able to do good in a larger arena," Das recalls. She agreed and debuted in 1997 by winning the local council polls and became the vice-chairperson of the Rairangpur municipality the same year.

After that there was no looking back. At the turn of the century, she contested an election for the Odisha assembly and won. She went on to become transport and commerce minister in the Naveen Patnaik-led BJD-BJP coalition government. Her colleagues remember her as






# ROAD TO RAISINA

### THE TRAJECTORY OF DROUPADI MURMU'S RISE FROM GRASSROOTS

### EARLY LIFE

↘ Born on June 20, 1958, in a Santhal family in Rairangpur tehsil of Odisha's Mayurbhanj district as the only daughter in a predominantly male household, Droupadi was doted upon by everyone

↘ Her father, Biranchi Narayan Tudu, was a farmer and her mother, Singo Tudu, a homemaker. Having studied only till Class II, Droupadi's father was keen that his daughter get an education, especially as his sons, Bhagat and Tarini, showed no inclination towards studying. Originally named Puti, she was given the name Droupadi by her teacher.

### EDUCATION

↘ Droupadi studied at the village school till Class VII. Having forgotten her compass in class once, she was given one by her teachers. Once she fin-